

THE VINE — Launch Budget

Athens, Tennessee | One-Time Startup | Target: ~\$100,000 (Debt-Free)

"Suppose one of you wants to build a tower. Won't you first sit down and estimate the cost to see if you have enough money to complete it?" — Luke 14:28

We count the cost so the mission can run unhindered.

GUIDING PHILOSOPHY

This is not a "build it and they will come" budget. This is a **portable, relational, low-overhead** launch budget designed for a bi-vocational planter in a small town of 14,000.

Core convictions: 1. **Leverage what we already have.** The website is done. Digital infrastructure, design, and much of the tech backbone can be handled in-house because of vocation and calling. Those line items are zeroed or minimized. 2. **Portable first.** No building purchase. No long-term lease. We rent space weekly or monthly (school gym, community center, theater) and we own the tools to set up and tear down fast and well. 3. **Frugal but not cheap.** We buy quality that lasts 7–10 years (good audio, solid trailer, real chairs). We buy used where it makes sense. We accept donations and discounts. We avoid debt. 4. **Relationships over production.** Every dollar either helps us gather (chairs, space, signage), helps us sound like we care (audio, lighting, hospitality), or helps us serve the community (outreach seed, launch team training). 5. **Setup/Tear-down reality.** The trailer and related gear exist because we are a mobile church that goes to people. That capability is non-negotiable.

The \$100,000 target aligns with the existing Fundraising Plan (\$80K personal + \$20K district match). This document is the spending plan for those funds.

BUDGET SUMMARY BY CATEGORY

Item	Details	Est. Cost	Notes
General Marketing Materials	2,000+ business/invite cards (quality stock, QR to Discord), 1,000 flyers (multiple designs), table cards, event graphics assets, cold brew dispensers + supplies starter kit, vinyl tablecloths, name tag station, "The Open Table" and "Terminal" standing signs	\$2,800	Core of every event and the 20 outreach points. Reorder from local printers (DRC Printing, Scenic City Signs) as needed.
Radio Ad Spend	WYXI (and WLAR/WJSQ) packages: 3–4 months of community event + awareness spots, 30s and 15s, focused on Respawn, Tech Help, Basecamp, Iron Horse, MooFest volunteer call, launch	\$1,800	Local radio still reaches a huge slice of Athens (commuters, older adults, working class). Packages are affordable.
Facebook / Instagram Ad Spend	Targeted geo ads (Athens + 15-mile radius): boosted event posts, awareness campaigns for launch month and first 3 monthly events, lookalike audience from early responders	\$2,200	Highest-ROI digital in this market. Run through personal/professional profiles first; boost strategically.
Print + Other	Daily Post-Athenian small display or classifieds (2–3 insertions), initial yard sign runs (20+ for launch directional), A-frames, one test poster-size or small digital billboard if inventory fits budget	\$1,700	Use sparingly. Yard signs and directional signs have immediate launch-day value.
ADVERTISING SUBTOTAL		\$8,500	See PUBLICITY-GUIDE.md Section 20 for ongoing annual estimates once launched.



DEVELOPMENT

Purpose: The foundation — legal standing, trained people, real presence in the community, and a place to meet. Much of the "digital development" cost is moved because it is already built or can be built/maintained by the planter's skill set.

Item	Details	Est. Cost	Notes
Legal Setup	TN Charter of Nonprofit Corporation (\$100), IRS Form 1023-EZ or determination support (\$275–\$600), basic attorney consult or online service for bylaws/articles review, EIN, Tennessee charitable solicitation registration (if required), bank account setup, initial corporate kit	\$2,000	Churches have automatic 501(c)(3) status in many ways, but incorporation protects liability and enables clean banking, insurance, and donor receipts. DIY-heavy to keep cost low.
Website	Already complete (the-vine-website repo + thevineathens.church). Domain + hosting costs absorbed in operating budget. No launch allocation.	\$0	Major "moved" item per vocation and existing work.
Launch Team Training & Equipping	Books/curriculum for Branches leaders (10–15 people), one-day offsite training retreat (food, space, materials), branded vests or simple polos for visibility at festivals (no big logos), background checks for all kids workers + leaders, name tags/lanyards, leader resource packets	\$3,800	Core of "Branches" (Point 4 in Outreach Plan). Investment in people multiplies everything else.
	Funding the 20-point outreach plan		

Outreach Seed (Year 1)	for first 9–12 months: food/supplies for cookouts & Respawn, cold brew ingredients, game night prizes, Tech Help clinic supplies, festival servant team t-shirts (subtle), United Way/LTNP project materials, Basecamp gear rentals (kayaks, etc.), Theology on Tap appetizers, neighborhood cookout permits + basic supplies	\$5,500	Directly funds the relational strategy. Every dollar here buys presence and goodwill, not advertising.
Office Supplies & Admin Starter	Dedicated laser printer/scanner (small footprint), paper/toner/labels for 12+ months, welcome packet folders & printing (500+), pens, tape, basic filing, PO Box or mail service if needed, initial check stock, receipt book	\$1,200	Keep it minimal. Most "office" work happens on the dedicated laptop and via Discord/phone.
Facility Rental (Launch Phase)	Security/cleaning deposit + 3–4 months advance rent for primary weekly meeting space (school gym, community room, SE TN Trade & Conference Center, or similar). Includes initial site visits and any required insurance rider for landlord.	\$6,000	Critical. Gives breathing room to launch without immediate cash-flow panic. Transition to monthly operating once stable. Portable means we are not locked into a bad long-term deal.
Cell Phone & Communication	Dedicated church mobile number (or Google Voice + hardware), phone, case, car mount/holder, 6 months service, professional voicemail,	\$600	One number for the community to reach the church. Planter already has personal phone;

	texting app credits		this is boundary + professionalism.
Training, Resources & Materials	Bulk Bibles (ESV or similar, 50–75 for Branches and guests), printed "Kingdom Theology" / Vineyard-style resources, kids ministry starter curriculum (print + a few physical books/toys), leader development books, "what we believe" one-pagers	\$2,400	Keeps Branches deep and accessible. Avoids expensive pre-packaged curricula.
Misc Development (Insurance Setup, etc.)	Initial liability insurance deposit/premium for first quarter (full policy moves to operating), accounting software setup (or free tier), any bond or background service fees, small contingency for unexpected legal or admin	\$2,500	
DEVELOPMENT SUBTOTAL		\$24,000	

EQUIPMENT

Purpose: Everything we physically carry, set up, tear down, and use every week. This is the largest category because we are choosing mobility and quality over a fixed building. Good audio + good seating + reliable transport = repeatable, excellent gatherings in borrowed spaces.

Item	Details	Est. Cost	Notes
			Highest single priority after trailer and chairs. Bad sound kills worship

Audio System & Instruments	Portable pro-level: 2–4 powered mains (QSC CP or K series / Alto TS410 or equivalent 2000W+), 1–2 subs or powered monitors, 12–16 channel mixer (or digital stagebox if budget stretches), 4–6 wireless mics (handheld + lav), stands, XLR/ speaker cables, DI boxes, basic IEM or wedge for drummer. Church backline: used acoustic/electric guitar, 61–88 key keyboard (weighted or good action), cajons + basic percussion, one small drum kit or electronic trigger set if donated/cheap. Cables, cases, mic clips.	\$11,000	and spoken word faster than anything. Buy name-brand used or new entry-pro; avoid the \$1,500 all-in-one "worship in a box" that dies in 18 months. Some personal instruments from team assumed.
Projector, Lighting & Screens	5,000+ lumen laser or long-life projector (Epson/BenQ), 120" portable or fixed-frame screen (or high-quality paint/wall treatment for permanent-ish venue), 6–10 LED par cans + simple controller + stands, HDMI matrix/switcher, long cable runs, 1–2 43–55" confidence or side screens/TVs for lyrics + sermon notes. Basic video capture if streaming later.	\$6,000	Lighting makes a huge difference for mood and visibility. Projector over TVs for cost and flexibility in different rooms.
	120–150 quality padded folding or stackable church chairs (dark color,		~\$30–\$40/ea new in bulk or good used/refurb from church liquidations or Marketplace.

Chairs	comfortable for 75+ min). 2–3 rolling carts or dollies for fast setup/teardown.	\$4,500	Start with 120; rent or borrow 30–50 more for launch day or growth spikes.
Laptop (Dedicated)	16" MacBook or high-spec Windows laptop for worship planning (ProPresenter or free equivalent), streaming, Planning Center/Check-Ins, graphic updates, admin, email. Dedicated church machine.	\$1,500	Vocation means we can spec and maintain it ourselves. Not a consumer laptop.
Stage (Portable)	12–16 ft wide x 8 ft deep (or modular 4x8 sections) adjustable-height risers, black non-skid or carpet surface, skirting, steps, safety railings where needed. Easy to load in trailer.	\$3,200	Professional look for band + speaker without building anything permanent. Skirts hide the ugly.
Kids Sound System	Small powered speaker (8–10"), 2–3 mics + stands, simple mixer or direct from main board feed for kids room/worship experience.	\$800	Separate from main PA so kids aren't blasting the whole building.
Kids Video & Lighting	32–43" TV/monitor on rolling stand or wall mount, basic LED wash for kids room, HDMI streaming stick or input from main system, simple lighting for safety and fun (no disco).	\$1,100	Nursery and preschool rooms need light and a screen for Bible

			stories/songs.
Kids & Nursery Supplies	2–3 pack-n-plays or portable cribs, changing station/table, play mats, age-appropriate toys & books (rotating bins), safety gates, first-aid kit, high chair, storage, hand sanitizer stations, "parent pager" or simple check system hardware.	\$2,200	Safety and cleanliness first. Toys don't need to be new — just clean and engaging.
Kids Check-In System	Tablet (iPad or Android) + rugged case + stand or kiosk, labels or thermal printer for name tags if using digital, or start with paper + migrate. Integrates with Planning Center or free/ low-cost alternative.	\$700	Critical for safety and parent peace of mind. Digital skills keep this cheap.
Signage — Inside	4–6 large (3x6 or 4x8) vinyl banners with grommets or stands ("Welcome to The Vine", stage backdrop elements, "Kids Ministry", "The Open Table", wayfinding, "Branches", "You Belong Here"). Hardware, poles, sandbags for stability.	\$2,200	Immediate brand and directional presence in whatever room we use.
Signage — Outside	4–6 professional yard signs (aluminum or heavy corrugated) with stakes for launch + ongoing locations, 2 A-frame sidewalk signs, window clings for venue doors, trailer vinyl lettering (logo + website + "Sundays"), one higher-quality 18x24 or 24x36 permanent-style sign (blade or monument style) for future or current visibility.	\$3,500	Outside signage is how the community sees us when we're not meeting. Phased: yard signs + A-frames at launch; nicer permanent piece once we have a

			more stable venue.
Software (One-Time / Launch)	Worship presentation software (ProPresenter license or affordable equivalent + resources), any needed graphic packs or fonts, initial ChMS setup (Planning Center Services/Giving/Check-Ins or free tier + migration), basic streaming license if used, stock assets.	\$1,800	Heavily reduced because of in-house capability. Many churches pay \$150–400/mo ongoing; we start minimal and self-host where possible.
Trailer (Enclosed Cargo)	6x10 or 6x12 (or 7x12) enclosed cargo trailer, good used condition or entry-level new 2026 with blackout/poly package. E-track or DIY shelving/organization system for PA, stage sections, chairs, banners, kids gear. Ramp door, spare tire, hitch work on tow vehicle, tie-downs, wheel chocks, interior lighting, lock.	\$5,200	Non-negotiable. This is the "Set Up/Tear Down vehicles" and equipment listed in the requirements. Without reliable, organized, weather-proof transport we cannot be portable and excellent. Buy once, cry once.
	6–8 six-foot folding tables + carts, fitted		Every gathering

Ministry & Hospitality Equipment	tablecloths (multiple sets), 2–3 commercial coffee urns/airpots + starter supplies, welcome table kit (table skirt, signage, pens, cards), 10–12 heavy storage totes, shop-vac or small vacuum, basic tool kit (screwdrivers, wrenches, zip ties, gaffer tape, multimeter), power distribution (4–6 heavy extension cords + distro boxes), first-aid + safety kit, cleaning caddy for venues.	\$3,000	needs tables for welcome, coffee, kids check-in, resource table. Power and cleanup gear keeps us good guests in borrowed spaces.
Resources, Materials & Handouts	200–300 high-quality welcome booklets or "Kingdom Theology & The Vine" packets, 75–100 Bibles for Branches/guests, kids activity sheets/curriculum masters printed in volume, "next steps" and interest cards, "The Open Table" handouts, any one-time printed "Launch Day" programs or maps.	\$1,800	Physical touchpoints matter. Keep design consistent with the website (dark, clean, vine green, JetBrains Mono accents).
Launch Day Specifics	Extra directional yard signs (10–15), two large "Launch" or "Grand Opening" vinyl banners, visitor gift bags (100–150 low-cost, thoughtful items — local honey, a book, mug, or "where you already belong" item + card), upgraded coffee/snacks for launch Sunday, printed one-time programs or maps (if used), photographer or basic video coverage of the day, any one-time chair/table/venue rental overage, parking or traffic help, small contingency for surprises.	\$4,000	This is the one day we may spend a little extra to feel special and prepared. Still frugal — no balloon arches or rented inflatables.
	Any hitch installation, minor tow vehicle		

Vehicles / Transport Buffer & Misc	upgrades (if needed), initial gas/maintenance for trailer runs, small contingency for delivery fees, tax, damaged-item replacement, or one-time gear we discover we need in the first 90 days.	\$3,700	Keeps the whole equipment package whole.
EQUIPMENT SUBTOTAL		\$67,500	

FULL LINE-ITEM TOTAL

\$8,500 (Advertising) + \$24,000 (Development) + \$67,500 (Equipment) = \$100,000

Actual targeted spend: \$98,000–\$99,500 with \$500–\$2,000 left as small contingency or re-allocated to first operating quarter if needed.

PHASING & PRIORITIES (WHAT TO BUY WHEN)

Pre-Launch (Months 1–4 of fundraising window): - Legal incorporation + bank account - Trailer + basic shelving/organization (enables everything else) - Core audio system (biggest quality lever) - 80–100 chairs + carts - Inside signage + basic outside yard signs - Laptop - Kids basic (nursery + check-in tablet) - Office printer + supplies - Launch team training retreat

Launch Window (30–60 days out): - Stage risers + skirting - Projector + lighting + screens - Remaining chairs to 120+ - Full hospitality/ministry equipment (tables, coffee, totes) - All marketing materials printed and distributed - Radio/FB/IG campaigns ramp - Facility deposit + first months secured - Resources & welcome packets printed - Trailer fully outfitted and labeled

Launch Day & First 90 Days: - Launch day specifics (banners, gifts, extra signs, photographer) - Fine-tune kids rooms - Any last signage or audio tweaks from real use - Begin monthly operating rhythm (insurance, rent, etc. move to ops budget)

Post-Launch (Months 4–12): - Upgrade or add as attendance and giving allow (more chairs, better lighting, permanent outside sign, second trailer shelf system, etc.) - Many "nice to have" items can wait for organic growth or specific donations.

KEY ASSUMPTIONS & FRUGALITY NOTES

- **Digital moved / zeroed:** Website, most software development, graphic design, some streaming/setup, and tech consulting are provided at or near cost by the planter's vocation and existing infrastructure. This is the single biggest savings vs. a typical plant.
 - **Bi-vocational planter:** No full salary in launch budget. Modest support appears in operating budget. This keeps the plant lean and the planter embedded in the community.
 - **Used + network + DIY:** Trailer, chairs, some instruments, cases, and furniture will be sourced used where condition is excellent (Marketplace, church sales, liquidation, personal networks). Core team contributes skills (wiring, shelving, painting, transport).
 - **Portable philosophy:** Every equipment decision favors fast setup (<45 min for full room) and fast teardown (<30 min) so we can use free or low-cost spaces and still feel excellent.
 - **Kids start modest:** Focus on safety, cleanliness, and warm welcome. Production (sound/video) is secondary to having caring, background-checked adults in the room.
 - **Signage is visibility:** In a small town, people drive by the same intersections every day. Good yard signs and a clean trailer with branding do more than one expensive billboard.
 - **No debt:** If a line item goes over, we delay or find a cheaper alternative (rent chairs for launch, borrow a trailer for first month, etc.). The fundraising plan already avoids the \$50k national loan option.
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WHAT THIS BUDGET DOES NOT INCLUDE

- Permanent building purchase or major renovation (future capital campaign)
 - Full-time planter salary or benefits (phased into operating as attendance grows)
 - Expensive video production or broadcast gear (start simple; phone + good audio first)
 - Paid staff beyond planter (volunteers and bi-vocational leaders first)
 - Large paid advertising after launch (organic + low-cost channels per PUBLICITY-GUIDE.md)
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STEWARDSHIP COVENANT

Every dollar given to this launch budget is a gift of trust. We will: - Track every expense publicly (quarterly updates to donors) - Buy once, maintain well, replace only when truly necessary - Prioritize relationships and mission over shiny objects - Return or reallocate any significant surplus to operating or mercy ministry

The goal is not a perfect launch. The goal is a **sustainable, debt-free, relationally rich** church that can still be excellent in borrowed spaces for years while we grow roots in Athens.

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"The earth is the Lord's, and everything in it."

We spend wisely because it all belongs to Him.

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Document prepared for The Vine Church Plant — Athens, Tennessee

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Aligns with FUNDRAISING.md (\$100,000 target) and existing Outreach/Publicity plans